

DESIGNER

BIBA



△ BOUTIQUE QUEEN

Barbara Hulanicki, the genius behind Biba, listened closely to her customers' needs and personally chose every item put on sale in her shop.

Less a label, more a way of life, the influential Biba brand of the 1960s and 70s blazed a trail for young, hip, high-street fashion and the affordable boutique. Biba's 1960s shops were a major democratizing force in a fashion world where the options were haute couture, trendy but pricey shops like Mary Quant's, or rather dull "grown-up" wear.

Mail-order origins

Biba was a marriage of Polish-born fashion illustrator Barbara Hulanicki's design genius and her husband Stephen Fitz-Simon's business savvy. In 1963 the couple started a mail-order clothes catalogue of Hulanicki designs that became the Biba Postal Boutique – named after Hulanicki's sister. After a pink gingham dress and headscarf was featured in the *Daily Mirror* they sold 17,000 units.

In 1964 the first Biba shop opened in Kensington, West London, and expanded rapidly, moving twice into bigger premises by 1969. Biba was a new kind of oasis, where friends met and shopped amid a unique, faded Victoriana created by low lighting and eclectic clothes hung from hatstands and piled on to antique furniture. Vibrantly patterned minidresses rubbed shoulders with feather boas, hats, lingerie, and accessories. All garments were originals, and were cheap and creative; limited runs ensured massive queues to snap up the latest offerings.

Personal vision

Hulanicki's visionary mix of Victoriana, Art Nouveau, 1920s–30s Art Deco, Hollywood decadence, and pop culture ensured that Biba quickly gained an international reputation. Biba

girls were independent and spirited but looked like big-eyed "dolls", with long, thin limbs and a flat chest. The distinctive Biba garment was cut with narrow, inset shoulders and high, body-lengthening armholes, with tight, narrow sleeves. Nostalgic "granny" prints and sombre berry, plum, and rust tones became signatures, as did smocks, huge floppy felt hats, and the skinny, chunky-heeled, squarish-toed "Biba boot" in canvas or suede – loyal fans bought several pairs in different colours.

Sophisticated styles were appearing by the late 1960s, including bias-cut, silky 30s-style dresses, cowl necklines, and trousers with panel features. Biba added children's and men's clothes, eveningwear, and household goods.

Moving up and out

In 1973 the "Big Biba" department store – seven opulent floors selling Biba-branded goods ranging from furniture to baked beans – opened in the suitably Art Deco premises of a defunct department store in Kensington High Street. Here, celebrities such as David Bowie sipped tea in a roof garden complete with pink flamingoes, as comfortable as the student crowd. Big Biba attracted a million visitors a week, but a gathering British recession hastened its closure after just over two years, and the dream came to an end.

Biba changes hands

The Fitz-Simons moved on to other ventures abroad and the Biba name was sold, the brand resurfacing in other hands. In 2006 Bella Freud designed a shortlived collection, and in 2009/10 Biba ranges were launched in two high-street chain stores. Items included a rose-print mini-shift with bell sleeves and a vampish feather cape – true to Biba's origins, but at higher-end prices.



FASHION ON A SHOESTRING ▷
For originality at budget prices, Biba led the way for a decade. This dress-and-trousers combination is from a 1967 collection.

TIMELINE

○ 1930

1936 Barbara Hulanicki born in Warsaw, Poland, and then raised in Palestine and the UK



< 1964 First Biba shop, selling clothes and top-toe accessories, opens in Abingdon Road, Kensington, London

1963 Launch of mail-order catalogue that became Biba Postal Boutique

○ 1960



1969 Move to first large shop in High Street Kensington

< 1966 Biba dresses in line with fashion of the time

○ 1970

▽ 1970 Biba cosmetics rolled out nationally; become Hulanicki's most successful line



1973–76 Short life of the "Big Biba" department store; Biba business declared bankrupt

1971 Menswear introduced

○ 2000

2006–10 Biba relaunched, out of Hulanicki's hands; high-street stores feature new Biba collections